



recognition that there was nothing official about unity except the official. It was that surplus of unities that made one realise that unity as uniformity may be parsimonious but unity in diversity required a semiotics of excess. It was a unity that allowed you to secede as long as Delhi didn't know it. For years, Satyajit Ray could be a cosmopolitan Bengali and deny that he was Indian and as Dharmendra once apocryphally confessed, "when he was homesick, he went to Birmingham". Hindi film had elements of what the subcontinental anthropologist Zia Sardar would call a "balti culture" and only *balti* sociologists and psychoanalysts could write easily and fluently about it. The literati saw Hindi films thrice to assure themselves that it was utterly boring, futile and meaningless. Condemning adult franchise and Hindi films was a hygiene that kept the elite together.

where modernity and tradition, legality and emotion, were represented in the struggles of two brothers lost in the childhood discovering each other and yet caught in the logic of their roles. Good triumphs over evil but within the framework of official justice. The wisdom of Bollywood lay in realising that one lived with contradictions, that there was both comfort and pain in stereotypes, that villains and vamps were alternative forms of imagination and that unity required hypocrisy and hysteria to sustain it. Mere logic left too many holes in the drama of the social resolution. Bollywood taught you that society was held together by infinite forms of glue, makeshift and make-believe, that unity required myths and that some myths were more equal than others, that family honour might demand a vengeance that the law could not condone, that the poignancy of life was measured in the gap



BASIC INSTINCT: In the aesthetics of violence, Bollywood conveys its limits as an ethics

As the nation modernises, myths have to work harder. Happy unities become uneasy contradictions, which have to be happily or unhappily resolved in three hours. In the 1970s and 1980s, Bollywood became a cultural machine struggling with the basic oppositions of modern India. These were basically five in number: the opposition of town and country, family versus state, cop versus criminal, modernity versus tradition and violence versus stability. Bollywood became a folk social science which grasped the poignancy of Indian society in a way modernisation theorists could not. Our films were not happy with hybridity or a simplistic opposition, they unravelled contestation through complementarity, reciprocity, incommensurability, translation; they explored sites where one had to yield to the official even if it did not do justice to social struggles. Bollywood showed that official closure as one form of unity always lives side by side with the struggles of unofficial emotion. So Hindi film became a drama of doubles, twins, mirrors

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between official and poetic justice, between the correct and the true.

Yet Bollywood of the '70s was still the movie of stereotypes, but it formed a self-correcting ballet with the rise of Amitabh Bachchan. Bachchan created a different kind of semiotic unity. He represented the dominance of the urban over the rural imagination. With Bachchan, India of the villages became pure nostalgia. With him, the village was a diminished urban fragment and modernity realised itself as a truly urban imagination. His anger, his violence represented the unified understanding of civil society after the Emergency that our institutions have failed, that old paradigms of civility will not work, and that Gandhi and Nehru are not frameworks of value but mere pictures stuck on the wall. The symbolic unity of India was the unities of corruption and violence, of a democracy hijacked by cynical manipulation. Bachchan represented the demand for a new language for the body politic.

Over time, Bachchan became a perennial, a collection of *rites de passage*. He moved from

